

Parmenides: monism



Around the beginning of the fifth century BCE, the centre of philosophy moved from Ionia to southern Italy, and in particular to the Greek colony of Elea. The founder of what became the 'Eleatic school' was Parmenides, who produced a counter-argument to Heraclitus's idea that everything is in flux (see [Heraclitus: everything is in flux](#)). Parmenides's argument was based on the idea that that you can't say of 'nothing' that it exists, and therefore there can never have been nothing: it cannot be true that everything came from nothing, so everything must always have existed – and will always exist since it can't *become* nothing either. The universe,

then, is completely full of *something*, which Parmenides believed was a single entity: all is one, uniform, unchanging and eternal. This view is known as monism.

However, Parmenides was also at pains to point out that there is also a world of appearances – the illusory world in which we live. This distinction between reality and perception was to become an important idea in later Western philosophy.